

ISLAM

In 1414, the people of Malacca (modern-day Melaka) converted to Islam when their ruler married a Muslim princess from Sumatra. The new faith spread rapidly throughout the country. Today, more than half the population of Malaysia is Muslim. Islamic law is widely obeyed and many women wear a headdress in the street.

Modern-day Kuala Lumpur is a mixture of skyscrapers and old colonial buildings.

**KUALA LUMPUR**

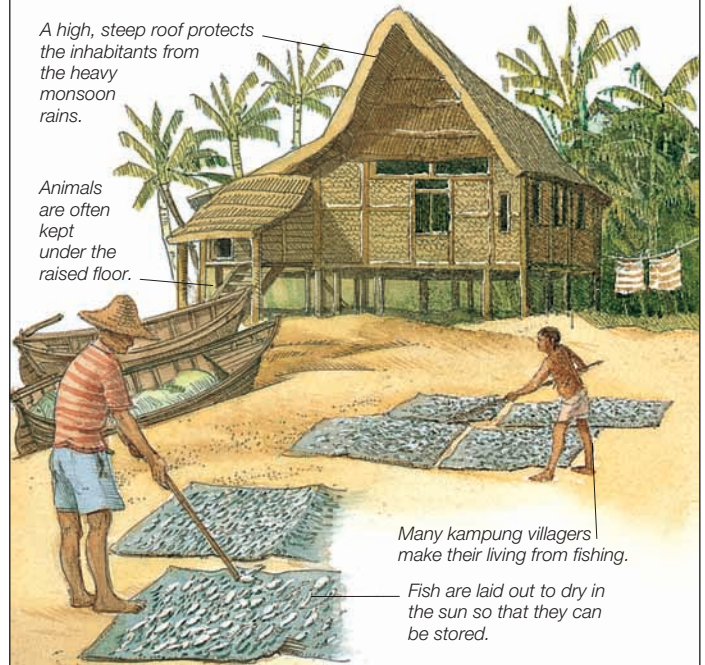
In 1857, a group of miners in search of tin set up a camp where the Kelang and Gombak rivers join. They called their settlement Kuala Lumpur, which is Malay for “muddy meeting place.” The camp soon grew in size and importance as a center of the tin mining and rubber industries. Today it is Malaysia’s biggest city and home to more than 1.5 million people.

LIFE ON STILTS

Faced with the problem of building on the banks of rivers or next to the sea, villagers developed an ingenious solution – they built their houses on stilts. Villages of these houses, called *kampungs*, are found throughout Southeast Asia. The wooden houses stand high enough above the water to protect them from flooding, while the raised floors and many windows help keep the houses well ventilated.

A high, steep roof protects the inhabitants from the heavy monsoon rains.

Animals are often kept under the raised floor.



Many kampung villagers make their living from fishing.

Fish are laid out to dry in the sun so that they can be stored.

SINGAPORE

OFF THE TIP OF MALAYSIA lies the tiny island state of Singapore, one of the most densely populated countries on Earth. Singapore was originally a trading settlement on the shipping route between India and China. It was founded in 1819 by Sir Stamford Raffles, an official of the British East India Company. Today, rapid economic growth has turned the island into one of the world’s most successful economies.

SINGAPORE SOCIETY

Three-quarters of the people of Singapore are Chinese; the rest are Malays and descendants of people from the Indian Subcontinent. Because Singapore is so wealthy, most people lead comfortable lives. The government keeps tight control over the country: it regulates the press, owns the television and radio services, and limits car ownership to prevent congestion on the roads. It is illegal to drop litter in the street, eat in the subway, or chew gum in public.

Singapore’s banks and stock exchange, based in this part of the city, generate about a quarter of the country’s income.

**THE PORT OF SINGAPORE**

Every three minutes a ship enters or leaves the bustling harbor of Singapore, making it the busiest port in the world. Tankers from the Persian Gulf bring crude oil to be refined into fuel and other products, which are then shipped out to ports throughout eastern Asia. Cargo ships on the way to and from China and Japan stop to use the harbor’s facilities, and most of Malaysia’s large export trade goes out through this port.

Singapore’s skyline is dominated by modern high-rise buildings, built because land is in such short supply.

Find out more

ISLAM: 275

OIL: 137, 152, 281

PACIFIC RIM ECONOMIES: 137

RUBBER: 226